



Enchantment of RICHES

IN A HISTORICAL ROLE REVERSAL,
EVEN THE ERSTWHILE COLONIAL
MASTERS ARE QUEUEING UP FOR
THE SERVICES OF MOTHER INDIA

BY WILLIAM DALRYMPLE

In January 2004, after a decade being away, I moved back to Delhi for the first time since publishing *City of Djinns*. I had come to research a new book on the city, *The Last Mughal*. The book was set in a period when Delhi was undergoing one of the cycles of growth and cultural renaissance: after the chaos of the 18th century, Shahjahanabad was thriving again and growing fast. A major regional economic centre, it was also a period of great self-confidence and artistic achievement—this was the Delhi of the ghazals of Ghalib and Zauq; of the miniature painting of Ghulam Ali Khan and Mazar Ali Khan; of the mathematical achievement of Master Ramchandra and the theological sophistication of Shah Abdul Aziz and Mufti Sadruddin Azurda.

As it turned out, I returned at a time when Delhi was again in the grip of

one of its intermittent periods of growth and productivity, not only in terms of economic figures but also in literature, the arts and the media. This was all immediately apparent: we had settled down in a friend's farmhouse in Kapashera, on the south western edge of Delhi, five kilometres from Gurgaon. From the end of my road, you could just see in the distance the rings of new housing estates springing up, full of call centres, software companies and fancy apartment blocks, all rapidly rising on land that only recently had been billowing winter wheat.

The first time I lived in Delhi in the late 1980s, Gurgaon had been a small semi-rural Haryana

market town, with its single large Maruti car plant on one side. It was a place that you had to pass through to get to Jaipur, struggling slowly through its streets as passing pedestrians wove their way through the traffic slowing your progress down the pot-holed two-lane highway. It was then home to no more than 1,00,000 people. Now, along with DLF, Gurgaon had suddenly grown to a glossy high-rise city of several million—some said two million, some said more: the speed of growth was so enormous, it was difficult to obtain accurate figures.

Four years later, with *The Last Mughal* now out in the shops, Gurgaon has galloped towards